

Alcohol Consumptions: Effects On Our Health

Alcohol, a non-negligible part of many cultures worldwide, holds a complex and wide relationship with human health. From its potential benefits to its devastating consequences, the effects of alcohol consumption on our well-being are intense and extensive. Understanding those effects is crucial for developing a healthy lifestyle and evolving public health strategies and interventions. This essay examines the result of alcohol consumption on our health and explores the effect on our cardiovascular health. The essay also delves into the irreversible impact of alcohol on the fetus of a pregnant woman and lastly examines the wider impacts of alcohol and heavy alcohol consumption. Through this examination, it becomes evident, that addressing alcohol consumption is paramount to safeguarding public health and reducing the burden of alcohol-related diseases.

Overall, heavy alcohol consumption may result in many heart dysfunctions, which can even lead to the death of a person. While heavy drinking has been longly associated with important medical and social risks, recent evidence suggests potential benefits from lighter alcohol intake, partly regarding heart diseases and other disorders. The definition (Klatsky A. L., Alcohol and cardiovascular health. Physiology & Behavior, 2010) divides alcohol drinking into 2 main categories. Firstly, the “moderate” drinking, which stands for max. 3 drinks per day and secondly, the “heavy” drinking, which means more than 3 drinks per day. Just to clarify, one drink denotes approximately 15 ml of ethyl alcohol. This distinction is important because it aids in determining consumption levels linked to not harming human health. Long-term consumption of a large number of alcoholic drinks per day may result in heart or nervous system problems (brain stroke etc.). Understanding these differences is essential for informing public health recommendations and promoting responsible alcohol consumption.

Cancer represents an important health challenge in Europe countries with millions of individuals diagnosed and a large number succumbing to this disease each year. Forecasts suggest a notable rise in cancer-related deaths by 2040 (H. Rumgay et al., The cost of premature death from cancer attributable to alcohol: Productivity losses in Europe in 2018, 2023), which could stimulate the implementation of initiatives like Europe’s Beating Cancer Plan. This comprehensive plan targets many aspects of cancer prevention and treatment, including efforts to reduce alcohol drinking, which is notably higher in Europe if compared to any other region. Alcohol consumption is identified as a factor for several types of cancer, such as cancer of the throat, oral cavity, liver, and breasts, contributing to approximately 180,000 cancer cases in Europe in 2020. In addition to the direct health consequences, alcohol consumption also imposes an important economic cost on society including direct health care costs and indirect losses like productivity. For instance, in 2018, premature cancer-related deaths resulted in estimated productivity losses of €50B - €53B in Europe alone. Furthermore, alcohol-related diseases and injuries led to a stunning €32.1B in productivity losses in 2016.

Alcohol’s impact on individuals includes the short-term effects of intoxication and the long-term effects on relationships. Short-term consequences, mainly between youths, include accidents or violent crimes. Approximately 25 % of alcohol-related deaths result from accidents, where alcohol worsens injuries in incidents like burns or drowning. From the social side, alcohol misuse disrupts familial and social ties (Therapondos G., et al., Health effects of alcohol and alcoholism. Clinics in Dermatology, 1999), leading to conflicts, divorce, or isolation. Due to alcohol-related accidents, that may result in jail time and further broken relationships, crime rates are rising quickly. Alcohol may psychologically worsen mood problems and

raise the suicide risk, at least in heavy alcohol drinkers. Alcohol consumption is also linked with mental illnesses like amnesia, sexual dysfunction, and personality decline.

Alcohol usage during pregnancy represents serious risks, where fetal alcohol spectrum disorder is the main problem. Despite health consultancies, a significant proportion of women continue to drink during their pregnancy, especially in the UK or Denmark. Marcella Broccia and her colleagues (Marcella Broccia, et al., Heavy prenatal alcohol exposure and obstetric and birth outcomes: a Danish nationwide cohort study from 1996 to 2018, 2023) performed extensive analyses spanning over twenty years in Denmark, revealing associations among maternal heavy alcohol use and adverse birth outcomes like preterm birth or embryonic growth restriction. Their research also emphasized links to long-term health issues in children including cerebral palsy and heart defects.

To sum up, alcohol consumption may be understood from many different points of view. Firstly, this essay researched the overall alcohol-consumption impact, where we have differentiated alcohol usage into 2 main branches – light and heavy alcohol intake. The small amount of ethyl-alcohol could be for the human body healthy and profitable. However, heavy usage of alcohol mostly leads to a decline in personality, crime rates, relationship problems, and so on. Alcohol users are also exposed to a higher risk of cancer. I am mainly talking about cancer of the throat or liver. In Europe, cancer illnesses are spread the most if compared to any other region. In 2018, there were recorded over 180,000 cases of throat or liver cancer in the whole of Europe, where we could say, that in most cases, alcohol played a huge role. There is no doubt, that drinking is dangerous for pregnant women. If we read some research on alcohol's influence on fetal, we would conclude, that drinking has many negative effects on the fetus. The newborn baby may be then exposed to a higher chance of heart defects or brain defects – mentioned cerebral palsy.

Alcohol is widely spread all over the world and used by many cultures. However long-term alcohol misuse often leads to uncountable negative health effects and mostly to death. So as it is always said, everything should be used moderately.

References

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